

8-figure CEO: a week in the dolomites building my business

Channel: Tim Luong · Published: Oct 06, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tl2v1Vp9wew> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Tim Luong documents a week in the Dolomites using it as a strategic retreat to plan Q4 and 2027 goals, aiming to double his 8-figure online education business from ~\$1M/month to \$2M+/month through focused initiatives and disciplined planning.

Contents

-  Arriving in the Dolomites & the Purpose of the Trip
-  3 AM Sunrise Hike & the Philosophy of Sprints vs. Routine
-  Spa, Slow Mornings & Recharging as a CEO
-  Deep Reading & the "What You Don't Know" Problem
-  Q4 Goal Planning Framework
-  The Three Core Initiatives for Q4
-  ADD, Shiny Object Syndrome & CEO Self-Awareness
-  Detaching vs. Being Present: The Switching Cost Struggle
-  16-Hour Workdays & the Nature of "Happy Exhausted"
-  Lago di Braies, Winter Arc Mindset & Starting Q1 Goals in Q4
-  New Hotel, B2B Launch & Free Course Sneak Peek
-  Recruiting A-Players: The CEO's Opportunistic Approach
-  Closing Reflections & Nature Commitment

Arriving in the Dolomites & the Purpose of the Trip 0:00

- Tim lands in the Dolomites for a one-week stay across three high-end hotels
- Primary mission: plan Q4 goals for his business portfolio
 - Runs an **8-figure/year** online business in multiple education niches
 - Wants to **double the business in the next 6–9 months**
 - Acknowledges this will require "the right key decisions" not just hard work
- Secondary goals: explore the Dolomites, create content, and reflect on strategy going into 2027

3 AM Sunrise Hike & the Philosophy of Sprints vs. Routine 1:05

- Tim and his crew wake up at 3:00–3:30 AM to hike to a Dolomites sunrise viewpoint
 - Described as "straight uphill for 3 hours" in an eerie, pitch-dark forest
 - Total hike duration: **3.5 hours**
- Key philosophy discussion on the hike — routine vs. sprints:
 - "Routine is maintenance" — once you have a routine, you're just sustaining a baseline of comfort
 - To break to a *new* level, you need **sprint periods**, not permanent grind
 - Example analogy: a 60–90 day boxing camp — after the camp, your baseline routine is now at a much higher level
 - Same applies to business: "You can't sprint every week in business, but you can for 90 days. Then maintain, recharge, and your new baseline is higher."
 - The hike itself is framed as doing something hard on purpose to shake the brain out of comfort
- Payoff: stunning sunrise views, described as "actually insane" and completely silent
- Post-hike breakfast spread: French toast, smoked salmon, fruit, protein assortment, yogurt — with a panoramic view

Spa, Slow Mornings & Recharging as a CEO 4:45

- Tim spends time at the hotel spa — 10 pools, 10 hot tubs, 6 saunas, all overlooking the Dolomites landscape
- Reflection on work-life philosophy as he gets older (10+ years in business):
 - Used to resist nature entirely; now sees value in occasional detox
 - "80–90% of the time, full sprint, gas in the pedal — especially if you're younger. But it's a marathon."
 - Starting to appreciate recharging so he can sprint harder afterward
- Message to his younger self: "You're always going to be too busy to work anyways. You're going to be working for the rest of your life. So you might as well get some fresh air."
- Brain clarity observation: sitting outside with nothing leads to slower, clearer thinking he can't access in his normal routine
 - "I don't know what it is, but my brain is just more clear. It moves slower."

Deep Reading & the "What You Don't Know" Problem 7:31

- Spends several hours reading a book recommended by friends with larger businesses
 - Does not name the book explicitly in the transcript
 - Friends told him he *needed* to read it to understand the next level of scaling
- Core insight driving the reading session:
 - "If you don't know what you don't know" — the gap between his current level and \$2M–\$4M/month exists partly in blind spots
 - Needs to figure out what operators doing \$2M–\$4M/month are doing that he is not yet doing

- Key quote from the book he shares:

"A small team of A players can run circles around a giant team of B and C players."

- Reflection on business fundamentals:
 - "When I review these books, the fundamentals in business never change. It's just the baseline bar of doing these fundamentals becomes so much higher."
 - Uses Mr. Beast as an analogy: anyone can make YouTube content, but Mr. Beast elevated every fundamental to a level that generates 200–300M views
- Recommendation: highly suggests the book to viewers; plans to finish it during the week

Q4 Goal Planning Framework 9:24

- After reading, returns to his hotel patio to map out concrete initiatives
- His planning philosophy — layering from vision to execution:
 - Step 1: Identify **3 main initiatives max** (not 4–5) for the 90-day quarter
 - Step 2: Write each initiative **very clearly and measurably** — not "grow the business" but "scale from 100K to 200K/month"
 - Step 3: For each initiative, map **one layer deeper** into subtasks
 - Step 4: Break subtasks into **weekly milestones** — "Week 1 do X, Week 2 do Y, Weeks 3–4 do Z"
 - Step 5: Each mini-milestone = 1/12th of the way to the 90-day goal
- Why 3 initiatives only:
 - "If I have four or five goals this quarter, maybe we hit a few of them. Versus if I just had three goals and we blow those out of the water."
 - Too many initiatives = team stretched thin = nothing actually gets done
- Context matters in goal-setting — example walkthrough:
 - If business is at 100K/month and you want 200K: ask if you can hire and train a closer from scratch AND ramp them in 90 days
 - If not: maybe aim for 150K, or maintain 100K but remove yourself from all calls
 - "It's not just as simple as 'I want to hit this number, so let's just figure it out.'"
- CEO leverage principle: "If I can just do **3–5 things max as a CEO** and nothing else this quarter, what do I need to do to add \$500K–\$1M/month?"
- The scoreboard question: "You can be busy, but does your scoreboard actually move every 90 days?"
- His team context: **50 people** all working on whatever direction he sets — wrong direction = 90 days wasted

The Three Core Initiatives for Q4 10:40

- Current business state: around **\$1M/month** — stable but plateaued at that level for a while
- Goal: **\$2M/month**, eventually **\$4M/month**

- Acknowledges this requires a different skill set he hasn't yet built
- **Initiative 1 — Launch a mid-funnel offer:**
 - Believes this will "at least double our lead flow"
 - Expected downstream effect: enables doubling the overall business
- The other 1–2 initiatives are referenced but not explicitly named in the transcript
- Overarching doubling strategy: figure out the 12-month goal, chunk into quarterly goals, execute quarter by quarter

ADD, Shiny Object Syndrome & CEO Self-Awareness 11:00

- Tim openly discusses managing his ADD as a CEO:
 - Constantly tempted by "new shiny object syndrome" — chasing new ideas and initiatives
 - Has actively worked on awareness so he doesn't confuse his team
 - "Sometimes it does still pop up and I'm not perfect."
- The discipline insight:
 - "Slowing down with a personality set like mine actually ends up winning in the long term."
 - Four or five goals = maybe hit a few; three goals = blow them out of the water
 - Too many goals → team burnout or paralysis from being stretched too thin
- Honest self-assessment: "All of these things are just goals and visions and none of it matters if you don't actually create a game plan to figure out how to get there."
- Frames his journey publicly: documents everything so he and viewers can look back in 5 years and assess whether he hit the vision

Detaching vs. Being Present: The Switching Cost Struggle 15:46

- Despite being in the Dolomites, Tim struggles to actually detach and be present
- Sources of mental load even on "vacation":
 - Business strategy and deep work
 - Active business meetings
 - Content planning (videos, shorts)
 - Managing people remotely
- Admitted failure moment: sat on the patio for **4 hours straight on his laptop** without looking up once at the mountains
 - "I could have been in a basement or a closet and I still would have gotten the same amount of work done."
- Solution he's forcing on himself: even **15 minutes at the pool** with no phone is enough to clear his mind
- Suggests that sitting in a meditative state — not thinking about business or content — is probably the most useful thing he can do

16-Hour Workdays & the Nature of "Happy Exhausted" 17:16

- Works from 8:00 AM to 12:35 AM on one particular day — a **16+ hour day** even while "on retreat"
 - Had meetings run over; wrapped a 2-hour call with his sales leader about Q4 numbers
- Distinguishes between two types of exhaustion:
 - **Bad exhausted**: working hard + losing, numbers all red, business on fire → one of the worst phases in business
 - **Happy exhausted**: working hard + winning, excited about upcoming initiatives → genuinely energizing
- On balance: "I talk a lot about balance but it's more extreme balance. I don't just sit around and travel. I genuinely love working."
- Self-awareness point: schedules travel and nature deliberately because he knows if he doesn't, he'll become unhappy from being too lopsided toward work
- Admits he's a natural workaholic — travel is a disciplined intervention, not a preference

Lago di Braies, Winter Arc Mindset & Starting Q1 Goals in Q4 18:57

- Visits Lago di Braies (Lake Braies) — rents a boat, gets B-roll and photos
 - Notes it's a very couple-heavy spot; he and his friend Johnny are the only non-couple on the lake
 - "I'm honestly itching to get back to the US. It's game time."
- Upcoming personal commitment: attending a friend's wedding in Lake Como the following weekend
- **Winter Arc / Q4 philosophy**:
 - "Q4 planning is more important than Q1 planning."
 - Best hack for hitting New Year's goals: **start them in Q4**
 - Spend 3 months building momentum so that on January 1st, you're already running — not waking up hungover and starting from zero
 - "A lot of people wait until New Year's to get started. I'm a big believer you should actually start in Q4."
- Nature tolerance self-assessment: went from never stepping foot in nature 5 years ago to tolerating it for "a couple hours max" — views it as personal growth

New Hotel, B2B Launch & Free Course Sneak Peek 21:17

- Moves to a new hotel: **Gonis** in the Dolomites
- Working at 5:30 PM reviewing designs for a **new B2B company** launching the following week
 - Shares a quick sneak peek of the designs on camera
- Also announces a **free 3.5-hour course** he created:
 - Topic: scaling online digital product / education agencies
 - Targeted at coaches and online educators ("coaches coaching coaches")
 - Includes a full workbook

- Describes it as a passion project where he poured in his knowledge
- May already be available by the time viewers watch the vlog
- Finds a new section of the hotel spa — sauna, steam room, outdoor hot tub with mountain views
- Reflection at the spa:
 - At 20 years old, he watched YouTube videos of digital nomads in Bali and dreamed of that life
 - Now living it on a casual Tuesday: "If you told my 20-year-old self this is the view I'd have on a Tuesday — what?"
 - Path to that life: build an online business, hire great people, build strong systems, and you can work from anywhere

Recruiting A-Players: The CEO's Opportunistic Approach 23:27

- Tim spontaneously meets a potential A-player (referred by an existing A-player on his team) during the trip
- His philosophy on A-player recruitment:
 - **"If I come across an A player, I will figure out how to hire them. Even if there's no role."**
 - Reasoning: A-players are extremely rare — they're already well-paid, in strong cultures, and don't job-hop frequently
 - "A players stay and they compound and they build."
 - Normal recruiting channels mostly surface B/C players — true A-players aren't browsing job boards
- The window of opportunity:
 - This particular person is available because their current company isn't doing well
 - They also have a personal connection to an existing A-player inside Tim's business
 - "They could go get another role tomorrow" — the window is narrow
- Current challenge: no defined role exists yet for this person
 - Tim's job now is to figure out what role makes sense where the **ROI justifies the cost** (A-players aren't cheap)
- Broader CEO insight: finding and securing talent is one of the highest-leverage things a CEO can do, regardless of whether a vacancy exists

Closing Reflections & Nature Commitment 25:42

- Tim stands outside at his hotel, taking in the mountain views between work sessions
- Genuine surprise at how much he's enjoyed the nature — calls not going out in nature more often "diabolical"
- Makes a public commitment:
 - Will **force himself into nature a few times per year** going forward
 - Viewers can hold him accountable through the channel
 - "Versus always wanting to be in this fast city life."

- Final vibe: working in peace with no one bothering him, incredible views, feeling good about the direction of the business heading into Q4